

WAITING TO TAKE WING A model of India's planned fifth-generation stealth fighter, Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA), on display at Aero India 2025 in Bengaluru, Feb. 11

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EALTH GAP



"INDIA NEEDS TO CATCH UP WITH THE LATEST TECHNOLOGY AND ACCELERATE ITS FIFTH-GENERATION FIGHTER JET PROGRAMME"

AIR CHIEF MARSHAL A.P. SINGH

Chief of the Air Staff, at the India Today Conclave

ment—maintains that the first flight will take place by 2028-29, with induction in the 2030s. But military aviation experts believe this timeline might already be too delayed. That's because China is busy mass-producing its fifth-gen J-20 fighters, having deployed a few along the Line of Actual Control, and is experimenting with its sixth-gen J-36 prototypes, unveiled in December 2024. What's more, even Pakistan is looking to procure a fleet of 40 J-35As—China's second fifth-gen fighters—from Beijing.

In a surprise move, Trump did offer India the F-35 stealth fighter—so far restricted to some NATO members and other key allies—during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to the US in February. This came soon after Russia—the only other country besides the US and China with fifth-gen capabilities—offered to co-produce in India its top-of-the-line Su-57E fighter. Amid these costly propositions, a high-level committee, led by defence secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, is racing to finalise a viable production model to accelerate the AMCA's induction into the Indian Air Force (IAF). The committee, which includes IAF Vice-Chief Air Marshal S.P. Dharkar and secretary, defence production, Sanjeev Kumar besides top minds from the ADA and the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), is expected to submit its report by the end of April.

PLAYING CATCH-UP

The evolution of fighter generations tells a story of key advancements in aerial warfare. Fourth-gen fighters like Russia's Su-30MKI and the US's F-16 dominated late 20th-century conflicts with manoeuvrability and heavy weapon load. The emergence of fifth-gen fighters—such as the F-35 and J-20—ushered in a new era, where stealth and sensor fusion rendered traditional air combat nearly obsolete. Their 'first look, first kill' capability allows pilots to shoot down enemy fighters or neutralise their air defences without giving them any